

# Black Banners — Condotta & Crowns

Wargame Expansion for Fate's Edge

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## I. Introduction: The Theater of Banners

### A. Core Concept

**War as Social Theater.** In Fate's Edge, battles are brief flashes. The story lives in the hours before and after: payroll arguments, muddy roads, who eats, who prays, who runs. Camps, fords, and counting-tents are the true stages of war.

**Mercenaries as Narrative Bridges.** Bannered companies move between courts, ports, and steppes. They tie urban intrigue to caravan legs, wilderness marches, and political endgames. Hire them, join them, outmaneuver them—either way, banners connect arcs.

**The Condotta System.** Contracts (condotte) are adventures in legal clothing: clauses, riders, sureties, and scheduled betrayals. This module gives you fast procedures to play the deal, the march, and the clash with the same tools as core Fate's Edge (Position / DV / Effect, Strings, and timers).

### B. Design Philosophy

**Camp Over Clash.** Put logistics, medicine, and morale on the table. The camp is where choices compound; the clash is where they're cashed.

**Contracts as Stories.** A charter's margins foreshadow your next session. Every clause is a future scene; every omission, a future wound.

**Dynamic Loyalties.** Allegiances shift without spreadsheets. One die per scene nudges fortune, pay, politics, and position.

**Cross-Arc Integration.** Banners bring Diamonds (leverage), Clubs (pressure), Hearts (people), and Spades (places) to any arc: court, road, hedge, harbor.

### C. Quickstart Summary

**Two-Minute Setup** A. Condotta Crossroads: Put two conflicting charters on the table. Ask who you disappoint first.

B. Company Sheet: Name, Colors, Captain, Cohorts. Add Payday [4], Supply [4], Cohesion [6].

C. Pressure Timers: Pick two externals (e.g., Skirmish Spiral [6], Camp Despair [6]).

D. Allegiances in Flux: At each scene start, roll 1d6 and apply the twist.

E. Honor Pragmatism: Slide the dial to reflect recent choices; gain a boon, pay a cost.

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## Lore: The Black Banners

“The contract is the road. The colors are the promise. The pay-chest is the prayer.”

The Black Banners are not one company but a league—a loose commonwealth of mercenary outfits that share camp law, pay customs, and a habit of turning up wherever the map is loud. Their colors are always some device on black: a lantern, a thorn, a bell, a fishbone, a broken scale. Black means coin before crown; witness before oath.

They are the thread that stitches frontiers to courts, caravan roads to siege lines. Ask five people who the Black Banners are and you’ll hear five truths: quartermasters who can feed a ghost army; paymasters who count twice; raiders with rules; peacekeepers who charge rent; undertakers who sing.

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### Origins & Reputation

- **Birth at the Crossroads.** The first “black” standards reportedly gathered during a famine campaign when city militias and steppe hosts both ran out of grain. A broker chalked clauses on wagon boards; those who signed swore to take coin, keep order, and leave exits. Black cloth was used because no city would lend its colors.
  - **Four Sacks of Ecktoria.** The empire counts four humiliations as “sacks.” The banners will say—privately—that the gates opened for Vilikari cohorts and Banners logistics, not for steppe charges. It was a war of ledgers, ferries, and night roads...and the empire paid late every time.
  - **Fierce, but priced.** Their reputation is a machine: frightening enough to deter trouble, disciplined enough to be rentable, and bound by camp law that courts grudgingly respect.
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### Articles of the Camp (the Eight You Hear Aloud)

- A. Payday comes before parley. No pay, no move.
- B. Leech and bell are sacred. Healers and chaplains travel untouched.
- C. Colors at dawn, not at night. Sacks and changes of allegiance happen in light, with a witness.
- D. Prisoners eat. Ransom or release; no starving.
- E. The broker is a bridge. Don’t kill bridges.
- F. Take no road you won’t defend. (Some add: “Leave two exits; take one.”)
- G. No fire in the hospital quarter. Even if the enemy runs through it.
- H. Count twice. Coin, bodies, promises.

Breaking an Article earns a Black Mark—a stigma that travels faster than mail. Three Black Marks and no reputable broker will carry your charter without triple surety.

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### How They See War

- **Camp before clash.** A battle is the interest on debts a captain accrued in camp: food, route, weather, rumor. If those sums are wrong, steel won’t save you.

- **Contracts as maps.** A condotta (charter) isn't just payment—it's terrain in sentences: rights of passage, shares of salvage, witness duties, who feeds prisoners and at what rate. Good captains can march through a clause.
  - **Loyalties in motion.** They do change sides, but by rule: daylight, drum, witness, surety paid. The gutter word is "treachery." The banner word is "rider fulfilled."
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## The Four Faces of a Banner (Hearts)

- **Captain.** Judge of risk and reputation. The best can smell a forged clause and a storm in the same breath.
- **Quartermaster.** The real warlord. Controls Supply, hates surprises, loves rain barrels.
- **Surgeon/Leech.** Holds morale together with needles, vinegar, and songs. Chooses who lives when coin runs out.
- **Scout/Sergeant.** Decides if today is a straight road or an honest ambush.

If Hearts are rotten, no Spade (place), Club (pressure), or Diamond (writ) will save you.

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## Colors, Devices, & Cant

**Common devices:** lantern, bell, thorn, chain, fishbone, ladder, broken bit, river-stone, empty ring.

### Cant phrases:

- "Black's the bargain." (We do this for pay, not love.)
  - "Lantern high." (We act under witness.)
  - "Count on copper." (Do it the hard way; stop promising silver.)
  - "Two weights, one truth." (Say the public price and the real one.)
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## Famous Companies & Rumors

- **The Iron Lanterns.** Siege specialists who promise no fire in hospitals and keep it. They claim to have taken five cities with fewer dead than one bad winter.
- **Thornwrights.** Sappers and road-cutters who price bridges by the breath—your breath at the gallop.
- **Bone & Bell.** Undertaker company; they bury both sides by the book and take payment in coin, land, or lineage favors.
- **The Fifth Pay-Chest.** An administrative company that "escorts" money and occasionally a colonel's conscience.
- **Sea Charters.** Colors on black sails; swear by Blue Moot tariffs; infamous for opening blockades with paperwork and weather.

**Rumor:** A captain called the Bannerless One walks with no colors and settles Payday by sheer presence. Those who accept their help wake with coin...and a debt that isn't money.

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## Brokers, Prefects, and Other Power

- **Condotta Brokers.** They draft the charters, carry news, hold surety. Killing a broker is like burning a bridge: possible, unforgettable, and expensive for a decade.
  - **River Prefects.** Stamps that open bridges—once. Prefects sell time more than passage; banners pay dearly.
  - **City Factors.** Neutral accountants; they read your ledger aloud and write you back into polite society—for a price and a favor. Many banners owe them Price of Neutrality.
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## Faith & Rites

- **Bell-Tokens.** Camp chaplains carry small bells strung with bone or copper. Three bells rung at dawn means a general amnesty for the morning: bury dead, trade prisoners, fix wells, no ambush. Violating a Bell Dawn is how legends end badly.
  - **The Surgeon's Right.** A leech can claim any blade or cloth in arm's reach during a procedure. Interfere and the nearest captain is obligated to cut you down or lose face.
  - **Break-Reins Rite.** When leaving a bad charter, a captain hangs a bridle ring on the camp gate. It means: we break this without treachery; pay our arrears, we'll bury your dead. Aveh's riders sometimes attend.
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## Money, Loot, & Shares

- **The Cut.** Standard shares: captain 3; officers 2; soldier 1; specialist +½. Horses get fed first, surgeons second, then soldiers, then officers, then captains. (Good companies keep it that way.)
  - **Black Chest.** An emergency pay-chest sealed under four keys—captain, quartermaster, leech, and the senior sergeant. Opening it without witness earns a Black Mark.
  - **Repair Years.** When a sack goes lawful but ugly, some companies pay in repair years—labor, stone, seed—rather than coin. It buys reputations you can recruit with.
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## Law & Punishment

- **Articles tribunals.** Verdicts delivered at noon, with the lantern high. Penalties range from dock of shares to branding (a small black banner on the forearm) to drumming out (colors stripped, tools kept).
  - **The Gentle Noose.** A derisive term for “polite” executions: a leather loop drawn until sleep—then a posting to the worst job for a year. Leechs hate it. Prefects love it.
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## Relationships & Politics

- **With Ykrul.** Respect and rivalry. Banners can pay for route rights with repair or coin; Ykrul will grant them if you hold your exits honest. Many Ykrul learned to price routes from banner quartermasters—and many quartermasters learned geometry from Ykrul judges.
  - **With Vilikari.** Symbiosis. Vilikari run night ferries, speak to both ledgers, and make false orders less profitable than a right bribe. Every good banner captain owes a Vilikari countkeeper at least one feast.
  - **With Ecktoria.** The empire hires, audits, and denounces—often in that order. Ecktorian “corrections” improve Position but put Black Marks on captains who say no.
  - **With Aeler.** Hire for stone and siege; pay in repair contracts and courtesy. Break a keystone charter once and all mountain roads become expensive.
  - **With Lethai.** Tricky. Lethai-al will deal if you respect hedges, bell dawns, and seed dues. Lethai-ar offer night work at good rates and terrible luck.
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## Seasons & Omens

- **Winter:** loyalty crystallizes or shatters. Good captains winter under charter; bad ones invent taxes.
  - **Storm Season:** the Blue Moot opens sea lanes or closes them. Sea Charters thrive; everyone else writes smaller letters.
  - **Omens:** a lantern that won’t light before parley; a bell that rings once with no wind; a pay-chest key that twists warm in a pocket.
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## What Everyone Knows / What Captains Know / What Only Leeches Say

**Everyone:** They fight for pay but keep rules that make them safer than warlords.

**Captains:** The real battle is Payday and Supply; break neither and you can lose three skirmishes and still win the war.

**Leeches:** If the camp sings, you live. If they stop singing, even the best charter bleeds.

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## Adventure Sparks

- **Lantern High at Noon.** A broker calls a bell dawn to arbitrate a massacre blamed on your colors. Find the forger, save the Articles, or carry a Black Mark forever.
- **The Fifth Chest.** Someone stole the black chest and left everyone’s keys in their boots. Recover it before Cohesion unravels.
- **Price of Neutrality.** City factors demand a favor: escort a despised official through your own angry camp during Short Rations.
- **The Bannerless One.** A quiet person clears your Payday problems and asks only for a prisoner you’d rather keep. Choose mercy, honor, or coin—then count the cost.

- **Bridge by Bell.** Blue Moot offers one bell-token to reopen a war-closed bridge for a watch. Who crosses first writes a season's history.
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## Using the Black Banners in Your Campaign

Drop a bannered company anywhere you need stakes with rules. They carry their own courts, hospitals, road crews, and songs. In intrigue arcs, they're leverage; in caravan legs, they're escorts or competitors; in wilderness play, they keep the wolves fed and the fires small; in political campaigns, they are the deniable arm of policy, standing under black to make the colors behind them look clean.

The secret of the Black Banners is simple: they turn war back into agreements. And agreements—like bridges—are only as strong as the people who keep them in the wind.

## II. Core Mechanics Framework

### A. The Four-Suit System

**Hearts (People).** Faces for your theater:

- Captain: command, parley, risk.
- Quartermaster: supply, pay, scavenge.
- Surgeon/Leech: harm control, disease, morale.
- Scout/Sergeant: terrain, ambush, tempo.

Use Hearts to bind scenes to stakes: who bleeds if this goes wrong?

**Spades (Places).** Position and Effect live in terrain: frozen fords, rain-cut roads, half-built siegeworks, forest lanes under truce. Spades name the rule of the ground and what it does to dice.

**Clubs (Pressures).** The SB menu of war: false orders, cut lines, camp-fever, gear breakage, rival aid that arrives late and loud, political "help." Clubs are how the Keeper spends setbacks.

**Diamonds (Leverage).** Fictional assets that bypass a roll once when you pay the price: safe-conducts, bridge priority stamps, debt notes, dispensation writs, blood-truce witnesses. Put at least one Diamond in every scene.

Use in play: At the top of a leg, draft one of each suit. Highest rank sets a major timer (4/6/8/10). Any Ace = winter & loyalty motif: expect hunger, omen, promotion-by-attribution.

### B. Company Sheet Structure

[COMPANY NAME] — [COLORS/BANNER]

Captain: [NAME]

Ledger: What we owe / Who owes us

Cohorts: Scouts • Sappers • Surgeons • Foragers • Skirmishers

#### TRACKS:

- Payday [4] — missed pay, bad terms, seized chests → desertion risk
- Supply [4] — weather, marches, sabotage → worse Position on maneuvers
- Cohesion [6] — losses, betrayals, humiliation → mutters → fractures

- Ledger Notes (Strings): broker's favor • bridge priority • chapel bell-token • banner voucher
- ford right (season). These are receipts you can spend.

### C. Track Management

- **Payday.** Tick for missed coin, broken promises, stolen chest, or a "creative" delay. On fill: a squad peels off, a veteran sells secrets, or the next Allegiances roll is with disadvantage (take the worse of two).
- **Supply.** Tick for hard weather, forced march, siege diet, or sabotage. While Supply  $\geq 3$ , all risky maneuvers start one step worse Position unless you bring a Diamond to bear (scavenge, requisition, dispensation).
- **Cohesion.** Tick for public humiliation, ugly losses, officer feuds, or moral injury. When Cohesion hits 0–1, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB each scene into Desertion, Brawl, or Refusal until you repair.

## III. Loyalty and Allegiance Systems

### A. Allegiances in Flux (1d6, scene start)

- Condotta Flip. Rival charter offers better terms. Take it: gain Black Mark [1] with the old patron. Refuse: tick Payday.
- Ykrul Counter-offer. Accept an exit-rich but costly route: start Obligation [2] you must pay in concessions later; refuse and tick Payday.
- Vilikari Shortcut. +1 Effect on this maneuver via night roads; Keeper gains 1 banked SB to spend as Hostile Terrain this scene.
- Ecktorian "Correction." March under "imperial guidance": +1 Position this scene or take a Black Mark [1] for defiance.
- False Orders. Clubs rain down. First command this scene risks misinterpretation unless countered with a Diamond (cipher, cantor, witness).
- Bannerless One. A myth-wrapped fixer clears Payday by 1—but starts Price of Mercy [2]. It will come due (prisoner release, repair years, or a refused sack).

Note: Allegiances events are biases, not dictates. They tilt Position/DV, start timers, or offer bargains.

### B. Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial

[HONOR]  $\longleftrightarrow$  0  $\longrightarrow$  [PRAGMATISM]

- Honor (left). +1 Position in parley/oaths; logistics burn faster (tick Supply on a partial where you'd normally be safe).
- Pragmatism (right). +1 Effect in ambush/sabotage; social starts one step worse Position when oaths/witnesses matter.

Centering Actions: pay arrears on-screen; return prisoners with witness; fulfill a broken writ at cost. Move the dial one step toward center.

## C. Loyalty Management

- **Black Marks.** Track public betrayals and insulted patrons. At 3, your Diamonds cost more: each use adds Political Pressure [1].
  - **Favor Debts.** Who owes you? Who do you owe? Record as Strings. Each unpaid Favor at arc's end ticks Cohesion once (soldiers smell unpaid debts).
  - **Reputation Shifts.** Recruiting in civilized ports favors Honor; hiring in hard fronts favors Pragmatism. Slide the dial to attract what you want.
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## IV. Camp Life Procedures

### A. Weekly Entanglements (choose 2 per leg)

#### A. Condotta Brokers' Syndicate

- Register colors and surety to bank Broker's Favor (parley DV 1 in camp).
- Skip registration: gain Unauthorized Colors—the Keeper can spend the first SB at a checkpoint as False Orders.

#### B. Camp Quartermasters

- Accept audits: cancel the next Supply tick on this leg.
- Refuse: start Short Rations [4]; while active, marching starts one Position worse.

#### C. Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles

- Tithe time or coin: clear Camp-Fever [1] each day, and the Keeper cannot convert the first 1 SB into Disease/Death this leg.
- Neglect: on the first Clubs spend, camp-fever blooms.

#### D. Steppe Envoys

- Keep rites (salt/water/shade): bank Remount Rights (once: +1 Effect on retreat/rapid redeploy).
- Break rites: gain Soured Oath (parley DV +1 with steppe peoples) until you repair with a gift or witness.

#### E. Hill Truce-Holders

- Stones-circle witness: bank Blood-Truce (cancel one hill ambush or demand parley).
- Violate: begin Guest Right Forfeit [4]; when it fills, locals refuse aid or safe passage.

### B. Soft-Power Integration

- **River Prefect Stamps.** Spend to claim Bridge Priority (crossing DV 1 once).
  - **Neutral City Factors.** Reroll a market roll in-camp; start Price of Neutrality [4] (the city expects something back).
  - **Border Monasteries.** Bell-tokens make the first Prisoners/Parley step safer (Position +1). Burn a bell-token for a clean retreat once/arc.
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## V. Combat and Campaign Integration

### A. SB Menu for War (Keeper)

When you roll 1s or on partials/misses, consider:

- False Orders (split unit, wrong target, delay).
- Ally Turns Sides (for a scene or for pay).
- Cut Supply Lines (tick Supply).
- Camp-Fever Outbreak (start or advance disease).
- Gear Failure (downgrade Effect; force scavenge).
- Reinforcements Arrive (tilt Position against you).
- Authority Intervention (political demand interrupts ops).
- Winter/Loyalty Omens (hard weather; Allegiances roll with disadvantage).

### B. Position/DV Modifiers (fast dials)

- **Weather:** Snow (1 Position), Storm (DV 1 to cross water), Clear (+1 Effect to ranged).
- **Supply:** Short (1 Position on risky maneuvers), Adequate (normal), Surplus (+1 Effect on prepared actions).
- **Morale:** Low (DV 1 to resist fear), Normal, High (+1 Position to hold ground).
- **Terrain:** Familiar (+1 Position), Neutral (normal), Hostile (1 Effect unless you bring a local Diamond).

### C. Campaign Timer Management

#### Primary:

- Payday [4] — financial pressure.
- Supply [4] — logistical pressure.
- Cohesion [6] — morale pressure.

#### Secondary:

- Skirmish Spiral [6] — tit-for-tat escalates into a war neither side budgeted.
  - Camp Despair [6] — rumor, grief, and boredom eat discipline.
  - Political Pressure [4] — courts, patrons, and prefects add new Prices to Diamonds.
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## VI. Scenario Seeds and Scores

### A. Contract Negotiations — Broker's Table, Two Ledgers

Two charters: one legal and thin, one dirty and rich. Pick one; secret the other as leverage (String). Attempt a synthesis by proposing a repair project that satisfies both—on a miss, start Political Pressure [2] and tick Payday.

## B. Crisis Management

**Plague Ground Sanctification.** Camp-Fever [3/4]; coordinate chaplains, leeches, and a bell-token circle to reset. Each delay ticks Cohesion; success restores one step toward Honor.

**Banner Swap in the Wind.** Colors change mid-skirmish; prove command while False Orders fly. Claim a Diamond (cipher, cantor, or witness) to hold line-of-command.

## C. Leadership Challenges — Field Promotion

A shattered unit's warrant lands in your lap. You inherit their Payday [2/4], Supply [1/4], and Black Mark [1]. Keep them intact for a leg and you gain Veteran Network (a permanent contact).

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# VII. Cross-System Integration

## A. Political Intrigue

Map condotta clauses to Influence ticks. Broker's Favor spends like a Boon. Black Marks behave like Exposure in social arcs.

## B. Caravan Operations

Quartermaster audits cancel the next Supply tick on a leg. River stamps reduce crossing DV. Vilikari shortcuts give +1 Effect and bank a hostile-terrain SB for the Keeper.

## C. Wilderness Survival

Hill stones-circles serve as safe trailheads (bank a Blood-Truce). Steppe rites (salt/water/shade) affect travel Position. Environmental hazards tick Supply instead of dealing Harm outright.

## D. Urban Adventures

City factors reroll a market roll; guild dispensations act as Diamonds. Municipal politics can rewrite the fine print on your charter mid-arc.

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# VIII. Character Options and Roles

## A. Company Roles

### Captain (leadership).

- Command, parley, and dial control.
- Once/scene: convert a No into a Project [4] if you can offer a witness.

### Quartermaster (logistics).

- Supply, audits, requisitions.
- Once/leg: cancel one Supply tick by cashing a String or finding salvage.

### **Scout/Sergeant (tactics).**

- Recon, ambush, terrain leverage.
- Once/scene: treat hostile ground as neutral if you describe the route.

### **Surgeon/Leech (support).**

- Harm, disease, morale rituals.
- Once/session: downgrade a fatal consequence to a timer the table can work.

## **B. Specialized Talents**

- **Condotta Veteran (4 XP).** +1 die on contract scenes; spot a forged clause on sight.
  - **Banner Reader (3 XP).** Read enemy disposition from standards; predict one Allegiances result per leg.
  - **Supply Master (5 XP).** Reduce Supply by 2 segments when you secure forage or plunder; scavenger rolls gain Position +1 in hostile terrain.
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# **IX. Campaign Framework**

## **A. Session Zero — Why This War?**

“Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to ‘contain,’ while companies sell steel to whomever keeps the books. Between rigid honor codes and steppe pragmatism, mercenaries survive by reading winds, not banners.”

## **B. Arc Progression**

**Act I:** Form up, take the first cheap charter, meet the brokers.

**Act II:** Run lean, juggle loyalties, pay or bleed for Diamonds.

**Act III:** A crisis demands a side; move the dial hard and live with the ledger.

## **C. Legacy Options**

- **Company Reputation** (affects future rates and riders).
  - **Veteran Network** (NPCs become contacts across arcs).
  - **War Stories** (Strings you can cash in other modules as legend).
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## X. GM Toolkit and Procedures

### A. Scene Start Procedure

- A. Roll Allegiances in Flux (1d6).
- B. Apply the twist (tilt Position/DV, start a timer, or offer a bargain).
- C. Check Payday/Supply/Cohesion; surface any on-3+ effects.
- D. Set baseline Position from terrain and the Honor/Pragmatism dial.
- E. Put one Diamond on the table (named, with a clear price).

### B. Pressure Management

**Low:** One primary timer in view; Diamonds plentiful.

**Medium:** Two timers pressure; Clubs spend once/scene.

**High:** Three timers hot; Allegiances roll with disadvantage; require witness to make anything stick.

### C. Keeper Cheatsheet

- Allegiances every scene.
- Payday/Supply visible at all times.
- Offer fiction-first Diamonds.
- Spend SB as: False Orders, Ally Turns, Supply Cut, Disease.

### D. Pacing Guidelines

A good banner session breathes:

- 2–3 camp scenes (contracts, audits, rites).
- 1–2 travel scenes (marches, scouts, weather).
- 1 major encounter (battle, crisis, betrayal) with at least one Diamond on the table.

## Followers: Condotta & Crowns

### Cap, Scale, Tracks — Core

**Cap (1–5)** measures capability (training, kit, doctrine). **Scale** is size: I (handful), II (squad), III (wing), IV (mixed-arms company).

- **Cap Edge:** If your unit's Cap exceeds opposition by 1+, choose *Position +1* or *Effect +1*. If lower by 1+, take *Position -1* or *Effect -1*. A 2+ edge shifts *both*.
- **Scale Effects (explicit):**
  - *Against smaller targets (you > target by 1+ Scale):* take **Effect +1**; if 2+ Scales larger, also **DV -1** on area/control orders.
  - *Against larger threats (you < target by 1+ Scale):* take **Effect -1**; if 2+ Scales smaller, also **DV +1** unless you use precision orders (Recon, Sabotage, Extract).
- **Follower Tracks:** *Loyalty* [6], *Morale* [6], *Condition* [3]. Companies also interact with *Payday* [4], *Supply* [4], *Cohesion* [6].

### Cap Progression (how it rises)

- **Training Project [6]:** Raise Cap by +1 (max 5) with drill + doctrine + kit refresh; costs 1 *Payday* and 1 *Supply* on completion.
- **Kit Upgrade [4]:** No Cap change, but treat the unit as *Cap +1 for Effect* until the next *Supply* tick.
- **Battle-Hardened (milestone):** After two strong-hit deployments without Condition loss, mark *Veteran*. Veterans resist one SB (see below) per scene.

### Follower ↔ Company Track Interactions

- **Bleed Up:** If a follower ends a leg at *Condition*  $\geq 2$ , reduce *Cohesion* -1 (once per leg).
- **Low Loyalty:** When a follower drops to *Loyalty* 1-2, mark *Cohesion* -1 or begin *Mutiny* [2] (Keeper's choice, fiction-led).
- **Low Morale:** If *Morale* 1-2, their first Order each scene suffers *Position* -1 unless *Payday* is cleared or *Chaplain/Leech* time is tithed.
- **Thin Company Tracks:** If the Company hits *Payday* [4] or *Supply* [4], each deployed follower tests *Loyalty* -1 on a partial/miss.

**Costs (mechanical teeth)** At *End of Leg*, unpaid **Costs** (shares, tithes, kit, audits) trigger:

- **Step 1 (warning):** *Loyalty* -1. If already at 1-2, also *Morale* -1.
- **Step 2 (arrears):** Mark a *Black Mark* on the Company (harder hires; polite courts treat Cap -1 for parley).
- **Step 3 (default):** Begin *Desertion* [4] for that unit or lock their Bandwidth (cannot take Orders) until paid.

### SB Resistance (Veteran/Elite hardening)

- Units with **Cap 4-5** or *Veteran* may *ignore* one **False Orders** or **Ally Wavers** SB spend *per scene*. Mark a small  $\diamond$  by the unit to show the resistance is unspent.

### Quick Reference (Cap/Scale vs Opposition)

| III Matchup Adjustment Example |                                    |                       |  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------|--|
| Cap 3 vs Cap 2                 | Choose Position +1 or Effect +1    | Vet Scouts vs Bandits |  |
| Cap 2 vs Cap 4                 | Choose Position -1 or Effect -1    | Regulars vs Elites    |  |
| Scale II vs I                  | Effect +1 (DV -1 on area)          | Platoon vs Team       |  |
| Scale I vs III                 | Effect -1 (DV +1 unless precision) | Squad vs Wing         |  |

### Order Economy (When to use...)

- **Hold/Grind:** When you need time/anchor; best with high Scale, high Cap.
- **Screen/Recone:** When information reduces DV later; best early, any Scale.
- **Raid/Sabotage:** When enemy Scale is higher; precision avoids DV +1.
- **Extract/Disengage:** When timers are hot; trades Effect for clean exits.
- **Seal/Control:** When the battle is won and you want revenue/safe lanes.

## Follower Sheet (Template)

|                                                         |                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| X                                                       |                                                |
| [UNIT NAME] — Colors/Banner: _____                      |                                                |
| Type: Bodyguard / Strike Force / Division / Company     | Playbook: Combat Ally / Specialist             |
| Cap: 1–5                                                | Scale: I/II/III/IV SB Resist: (Vet/Elite only) |
| Capabilities: _____                                     |                                                |
| Edges: _____                                            | Liabilities: _____                             |
| Strings: _____                                          | Costs: _____                                   |
| Tracks: Loyalty [__/6], Morale [__/6], Condition [__/3] |                                                |
| Tags: _____                                             |                                                |
| Current Deployment: _____                               | Active Orders: _____                           |

### Elite Bodyguards

Captain's Guard Cap: 4    Scale: I    SB Resist:  
Playbook: Combat Ally  
Capabilities: Close protection, command, last-man extraction  
Edges: Veteran drills; duelists    Liabilities: Oath scruples  
Strings: Captain's favor; court dispensation    Costs: Shares; oath service  
Tracks: Loyalty 5/6, Morale 4/6, Condition 0/3  
Tags: Elite Training, Oath-Bound, Honor Guard  
Current Deployment: Staff HQ    Active Orders: Interpose

**Orders** **Interpose** (protect principal); **Counterstroke** (impose *Disarray* [2]); **Screen & Extract**.

Shield-Sister Cohort Cap: 3    Scale: I–II  
Playbook: Combat Ally  
Capabilities: Formation fighting, shield wall  
Edges: Silent signals    Liabilities: Slow pivot  
Strings: Clan bonds    Costs: Tithes; weapon upkeep  
Tracks: Loyalty 4/6, Morale 5/6, Condition 0/3  
Tags: Shield Wall, Clan-Bonded, Formation Fighters

**Orders** **Hold the Door; Shield Ram**.

### Small Strike Forces

Scout-Veterans Cap: 3    Scale: I–II  
Playbook: Specialist  
Capabilities: Recon, ambush, rapid deploy  
Edges: Terrain mastery    Liabilities: Independent streak  
Strings: Scout nets    Costs: Danger pay; kit  
Tracks: Loyalty 3/6, Morale 4/6, Condition 0/3  
Tags: Scout Eyes, Rapid Deployment, Terrain Masters

**Orders** **Eyes Forward** (make *Flank* [2]); **Night Harass** (tick *Skirmish Spiral*, stay unseen or Cohesion –1).

Sapper Crew Cap: 3    Scale: I–II  
Playbook: Specialist  
Capabilities: Siege, demo, field engineering  
Edges: Structural sense    Liabilities: Accident risk  
Strings: Engineer tools    Costs: Hazard pay; materials  
Tracks: Loyalty 4/6, Morale 3/6, Condition 1/3  
Tags: Hazardous, Siege Experts, Mobile Assets

**Orders**   **Breach** (advance *Breach* [4]); **Field Fix** (restore ally Position).

### Condotta Divisions

Banner Sergeants Cap: 3    Scale: II–III  
Playbook: Combat Ally  
Capabilities: Unit command, rally  
Edges: Tactical precision    Liabilities: Banner pride  
Strings: Banner rights    Costs: Command shares  
Tracks: Loyalty 4/6, Morale 5/6, Condition 0/3  
Tags: Unit Command, Tactical Experts, Banner-Bound

**Orders**   **Dress the Line** (stabilize & Position +1); **Push of Pike** (advance, *Rout* [1] on strong).

Condotta Engineers Cap: 2    Scale: II  
Playbook: Specialist  
Capabilities: Logistics, repair  
Edges: Resource efficiency    Liabilities: Bureaucratic friction  
Strings: Supply stamps    Costs: Admin overhead; audits  
Tracks: Loyalty 3/6, Morale 4/6, Condition 0/3  
Tags: Logistics Masters, Supply Chain, Administrative

**Orders**   **Open the Road** (reduce *Supply*); **Patch & Prep** (clear Condition or create *Reserve* [1]).

### Condotta Companies

Mercenary Company (Small) — *The Iron Lanterns* Cap: 3–4    Scale: III    SB Resist:  
Playbook: Combat Ally  
Capabilities: Siege ops, heavy weapons  
Edges: Bombard train    Liabilities: Heavy upkeep  
Strings: Siege contracts    Costs: Veteran pay; trains  
Cohorts: 20 vets, 10 support, 5 engineers  
Tracks: Cohesion 6/8, Exposure 2/6, Resources 4/6  
Bandwidth: 3 orders/leg    Tags: Siege Specialists, Heavy Weapons

**Orders**   **Lines & Batteries** (Breach/Starve); **Seal the Gate** (convert *Control* to tolls or safe lanes).

Condotta Company (Large) — *Thornwrights* Cap: 3    Scale: IV  
Playbook: Combat Ally  
Capabilities: Road cutting, sapper ops, mobility

Edges: Bridge kits    Liabilities: Supply-intensive  
 Strings: Road contracts    Costs: Materials; fuel/forage  
 Cohorts: 40 combat, 20 engineers, 15 support  
 Tracks: Cohesion 7/8, Exposure 3/6, Resources 5/6  
 Bandwidth: 4 orders/leg    Tags: Mobile Assets, Engineering Corps

**Orders**    **March Lanes** (create *Safe Lane*); **Cut & Run** (deny road; enemy *Supply* -1 on strong).

## War Table: The Black Banners Wargame Extension

### Scope & Assumptions

This extension escalates Black Banners from company skirmishes to banner-on-banner engagements, using the core *Miniatures and Tactical Layer* (ZOC, facing/flanking, special actions) and *Mass Combat* scaffolding. The Keeper still adjudicates Position/Effect and DV, but units act as Followers at formation scale with clear Orders, Cohesion, and Supply interplay.

### Table Scale & Bases

- **Grid:** Hex or square, as per core; declare at setup.
- **Base Sizes:** *Skirmish* (1–6 models) = Small; *Troop/Line* (8–16) = Medium; *Detachment* (20–40) = Large; *Wing/Battalion* (40+) = Huge.
- **Facing/Flank:** Use core facing; Flank = +1 die, Rear = +1 die and +1 Effect.
- **ZOC:** Entering enemy ZoC ends movement; leaving requires Disengage (DV 4–6) or a Boon.

### Unit Profile (Cap & Scale)

Each unit uses a compact profile:

**Name** | *Type* | *Cap*(1 – 5) | *Scale* | *Speed* | *Tags*(2) | *Tracks* : *Loyalty, Morale, Condition* | *Costs*

**Cap (1–5)**    A qualitative "tier" of training/equipment. *Cap usually rises through XP milestones, training projects, and kit upgrades delivered by Quartermasters between legs.* (See §2.13.)

**Scale**    Abstract size band (Small/Med/Large/Huge). Use for reach, frontage, and the *Scale Edge* rule below.

### Scale Edge (quick effect dial)

When Scale differs, apply *one* of the following edge nudges (attacker chooses):

- **+1 Position** *or* **+1 Effect** if attacker's Scale > defender's.
- **+1 DV** against attacks if defender's Scale > attacker's.

*Design note: This keeps Scale impactful without new math bloat; it layers on top of core DV/Position.*



## Turn Structure (War Table)

Rounds comprise the following phases: ,label=.

- A. **Command** (hidden): Captains assign *Orders* to each unit; reveal simultaneously.
- B. **Maneuver**: Move units (Speed, ZoC applies). Facing is chosen at end of move.
- C. **Actions**: Attack, Rally, Assist, Special, or Resolve Order effects.
- D. **End Step**: Check *Cohesion*, *Supply*, and event timers; apply attrition.

### III Your Unit Opposition Edge (crib)

Cap 0 (Levy) Drill Troops (Cap 1) You: Position -1 (unless bolstered)  
Cap 1 (Trained) Militia/Levy (Cap 0-1) +1 Position when fresh  
Cap 2 (Veteran) Bandits/Levy (Cap 1-2) +1 die on first decisive action  
Cap 3 (Elite) Regulars (Cap 2-3) +1 Effect on charge/volley  
Cap 4 (Prime) Guard/Chosen (Cap 3-4) Ignore 1 SB war-complication/round  
Cap 5 (Legend) Champions (Cap 4-5) Once/round bump Position up one step

**Movement, Speed, Terrain, Scale.** **Speed** is your Movement Points (MP) budget each round; you spend MP *per hex* moved in the Maneuver phase.

- **Base Costs (per hex)**: Open/Field = 1 MP; Road = 1 MP (ignore first Difficult modifier); Difficult (forest, rubble, marsh) = 2 MP; Very Difficult (bog, scree, shallow water) = 3 MP; Impassable = 0 MP (no entry).
- **Elevation**: Moving *up* a level costs +1 MP; moving *down* is free but may require a test if the hex is Hazardous.
- **Scale Modifiers (per hex)**:
  - *Large/Huge* in *Constricted* or *Difficult* terrain (woods, streets, rubble): +1 MP *per hex*.
  - *Small* skirmish units: ignore the first +1 MP from *Difficult* once per round (they flow).
  - *Road Columns*: Any Scale on a Road ignores Scale penalties while *in column*; entering/leaving column costs 1 MP.

*Example*: A Large unit moving through **Difficult Forest** pays **3 MP per hex** (2 MP Difficult + 1 MP Scale). If also going *up* elevation, that hex costs **4 MP**. These costs are *per hex*, not a one-time surcharge.

**Action & Reaction Economy.** Each unit follows a simple economy each round:

- A. **Order (1)** declared in Command phase (e.g., *Advance & Hold*, *Flank & Strike*, *Volley/Overwatch*, *Rally & Reform*, *Sapper Work*, *Logistics Action*).
- B. **Movement (Maneuver)** spends *Speed* (MP) according to terrain/Scale.
- C. **Primary Action (1)** in the Actions phase, as specified by the Order (attack, rally, breach, etc.).
- D. **Reaction (up to 1/round, optional)** may trigger outside your turn when a listed trigger occurs.

**Reactions are in addition to your primary action** but limited to *one per round per unit*. Mark a small  $\diamond$  beside the unit when its reaction is spent; clear all reaction markers in the End Step.

### Common Reaction Triggers (choose one to resolve).

- **Free Strike:** An enemy leaves your ZoC without Disengaging (DV 4-6).
- **Brace:** An enemy *enters* your front arc from  $\geq 2$  hexes away; gain Position +1 versus that charge/attack.
- **Overwatch Fire:** If your unit set *Volley/Overwatch* this round, make one prepared attack when the first enemy crosses your lane.
- **Counterpush:** If an enemy resolves a *Shock Push* into your hex, test to Shove 1 hex back on a hit (opposed).

*Notes:* (1) *Skirmish Screen* grants a *free Disengage* during your move; it is *not* a reaction. (2) Orders that set a posture (e.g., *Volley/Overwatch*) *consume your action*, and the triggered shot uses your one reaction for the round. (3) Some tags (e.g., *Line-Drilled*) may grant a *bonus reaction* 1/round; if so, it will be stated on the unit.

### Cheatline:

*Order (1)  $\Rightarrow$  Move (MP)  $\Rightarrow$  Primary Action (1) | Reaction: max 1/round when triggered*

### Orders Economy (choose one per unit/round)

#### Advance & Hold

Move up to Speed, then Guard. Good for line stabilization.

#### Flank & Strike

Move; if you end in a flank/rear arc, gain +1 die on one attack.

#### Skirmish Screen

Enter/exit ZoC freely once (auto-Disengage), but attacks are Limited.

#### Shock Push

Attempt a Tackle/Shove (DV 4-6); on success, Push 1-2 hexes and degrade foe Position.

#### Volley/Overwatch

Gain Aim benefits (+1 die or +1 Effect), threaten a lane as a Reaction.

#### Rally & Reform

Test *Morale*; on success, clear 1 *Morale* and 1 *Condition*.

#### Sapper Work

Place/clear obstacles, breach, or entrench; set a Terrain Tag for your hex/ring.

#### Logistics Action

Reduce Company *Supply* by 1 to remove 1 *Condition* from this unit.

### Cap vs. Typical Foes (Keeper crib)

#### III Your Unit Opposition Edge

|                 |                        |                                       |
|-----------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Cap 1 (Trained) | Militia (Cap 0-1)      | +1 Position when fresh                |
| Cap 2 (Veteran) | Bandits/Levy (Cap 1-2) | +1 die on first decisive action       |
| Cap 3 (Elite)   | Regulars (Cap 2-3)     | +1 Effect on charge/volley            |
| Cap 4 (Prime)   | Guard/Chosen (Cap 3-4) | Resist 1 SB war-complication/round    |
| Cap 5 (Legend)  | Champions (Cap 4-5)    | Once/round, bump Position up one step |

## Followers & Companies at War

**Tracks that Talk.** Individual *Loyalty/Morale/Condition* bleed upward: at the end of any round where  $\geq 2$  units are at  $Morale \leq 2$  or  $Condition \geq 2$ , tick Company *Cohesion* +1. When Company *Cohesion* drops a step (e.g., 4/6  $\rightarrow$  5/6), all units take *Position* -1 until a Rally succeeds.

**Costs with Teeth.** If a unit's *Costs* go unpaid this leg, it immediately suffers *Loyalty* -1 and starts a *Desertion* [3] timer; on fill, remove the unit or convert it to *Bannerless* (hostile neutral).

**Veteran Resilience.** Veteran/Elite units may *ignore one SB war-complication per battle* (once)—or convert it into *Condition* +1 instead.

## Cohesion, Payday, Supply (Company Sync)

### Payday (4)

Missed payments or broken writs tick this. On fill: *Loyalty* -1 to all units; begin *Pay Raid* [4] as soldiers self-requisition.

### Supply (4)

Weather, hard marches, or requisition burn. On fill: all *Logistics Actions* fail this round; ranged units lose *Volley*.

### Cohesion (6)

Losses, betrayals, poor command. Each step past 4/6 imposes army-wide *Position* -1 until *Rally & Reform* succeeds twice.

## Terrain & Weather (quick plugs)

- **Difficult:** 2 MP/hex; **Elevation:** +1 DV from below; **Cover:** *Position* up a step.
- **Storm:** DV -1 for movement tests; **Snow:** *Position* -1 unless *Cold-Drilled*.

## Orders—"When to Use" Quick Guide

- **I need to pin their center**  $\rightarrow$  Advance & Hold (then Guard).
- **I need a decisive break**  $\rightarrow$  Shock Push into Rear/Flank.
- **Their light troops harass us**  $\rightarrow$  Skirmish Screen.
- **We're wavering**  $\rightarrow$  Rally & Reform (twice if Cohesion is slipping).
- **We can grind them**  $\rightarrow$  Volley/Overwatch to tax approaches.
- **Fort ahead**  $\rightarrow$  Sapper Work to set breach/climb tags.

## Active Orders Box (per unit)

p0.92 **Current Deployment:** \_\_\_\_\_ **Active Order:** \_\_\_\_\_ **Objective:** \_\_\_\_\_  
**Status:** *Loyalty* \_\_\_/6 *Morale* \_\_\_/6 *Condition* \_\_\_/3 | **Costs Due:** \_\_\_\_\_

## Cap Advancement & Projects

- **Training Project** (*Company Phase*): Spend coin/scrip; complete *Drill [6]*; raise one unit's *Cap* by +1 (max 5). On completion, mark *Supply* +1 (ammo/equipment burn).
- **Kit Upgrade**: Attach a Diamond-tier asset (engine, plate, chassis); gain a situational Tag for the campaign (*Siege-Drilled*, *Cold-Drilled*, *River-Rated*).
- **Veteran Cross-posting**: Move a veteran cadre into a green unit; both roll *Morale*. On success, mentees gain temporary +1 die on their next Rally or Advance.

## SB Menu for War (Keeper)

- **False Orders** (colors flipped at a ford)
- **Ally Turns Sides** (Favor Debt called)
- **Cut Lines** (Supply +1, Cohesion +1)
- **Camp-Fever** (disease outbreak; Condition +1 unless Chaplains/Leeches intervene)
- **Gear Shear** (siege tool failure; lose Sapper Work this round)
- **Authority Edict** (political interference; Position -1 in parley or movement)

## Setups & Diamonds

- **River Prefect Stamps**: Crossing DV -1; one forced march ignores Difficult once.
- **Broker's Favor**: Parley DV -1 on contract scenes; on miss, gain a Black Mark.
- **Bell-Tokens**: Safer prisoner handling; cancel one *Ally Turns Sides*.

## Worked Micro-Scenario

"Banner Swap in the Wind." A rival plants *False Orders*. Roll *Allegiances in Flux* at start. Your Vanguard (Cap 3, Medium, Tags: *Line-Drilled*, *Cold-Drilled*) declares *Advance & Hold*; your Lights (Cap 2, Small, *Skirmish*) declare *Skirmish Screen*. Enemy hits your flank; you answer with *Shock Push* from Reserve (Cap 3, Large *Cavalry*). If two of your units end the round with *Morale*  $\leq 2$ , tick Company *Cohesion* +1 and apply army-wide Position -1 until double Rally succeeds.

## Reference Tabs

- **Facing/Flank**: +1 die (Flank), +1 die and +1 Effect (Rear).
- **ZOC**: Enter stops, exit needs Disengage (DV 4-6) or Boon.
- **Terrain**: Difficult = 2 MP/hex; Elevation = +1 DV from below; Cover raises Position.
- **Reactions**: Each unit 1/round (Free Strike or Shove 1 on ZoC leave).